The Zoo Story

The Anatomy of an Encounter

A Visual Analysis of Alienation & Psychology
in Edward Albee's Absurdist Classic

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1

Written by Edward Albee

Postmodernism begins.

2

Theatre of the Absurd

Routine meets Impulse.

3

The Zoo Story

Civilization vs. Instinct

The title is symbolic. The setting is near a zoo, representing the tension between the City (Society) and the Animal (Instinct). It posits that modern humans are caged.

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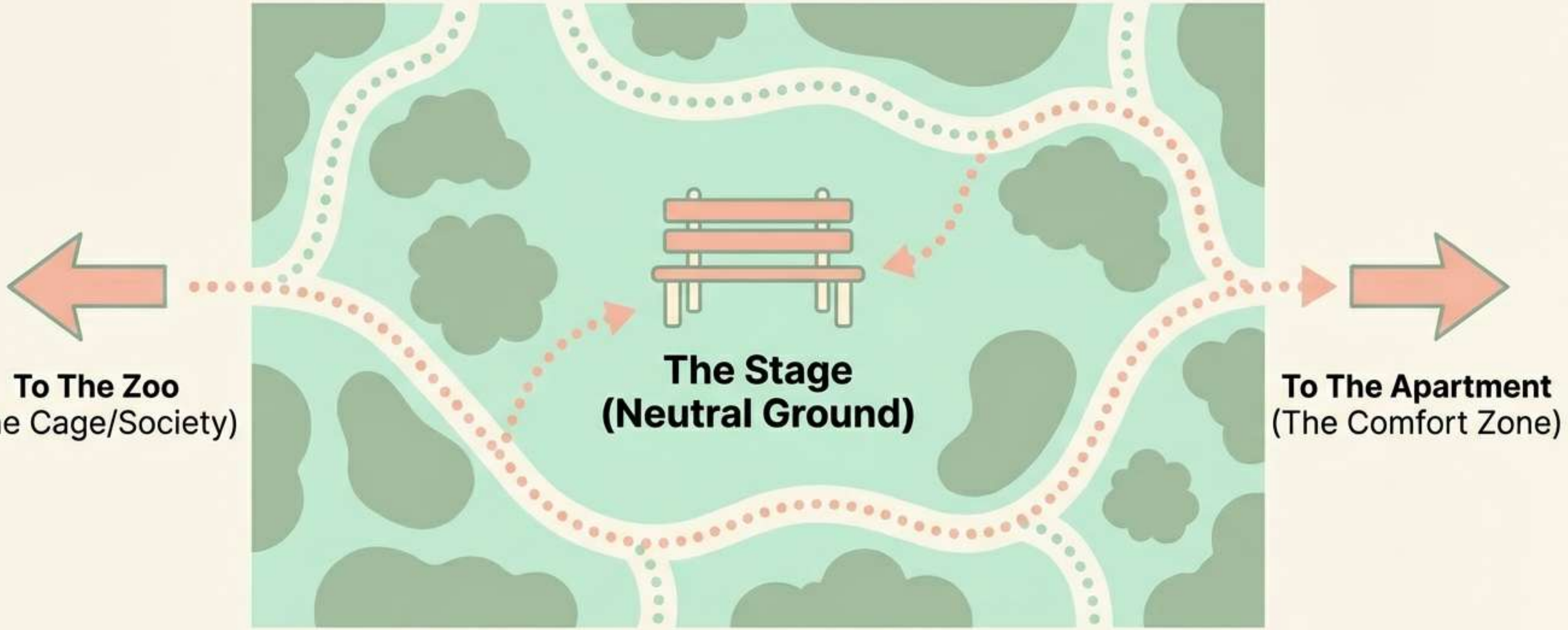
The Setting: Central Park



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Peter: The Static Object

Comfortable Middle-Class.
Structured, conservative life.

Emotionally Numb.
Isolated by comfort.

Passive & Avoidant
Prefers reading to interacting.

Psychology: Internalized Trauma
Psychology: Internalized Trauma. Fear of the unknown and emotional repression.

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Jerry: The Kinetic Force

Aggressive & Raw
Challenges norms to provoke.

Alienated
A “caged animal” desperate for notice.

Volatile
Uses confrontation as communication.

Psychology: Externalized Trauma. Loneliness turned into aggression.

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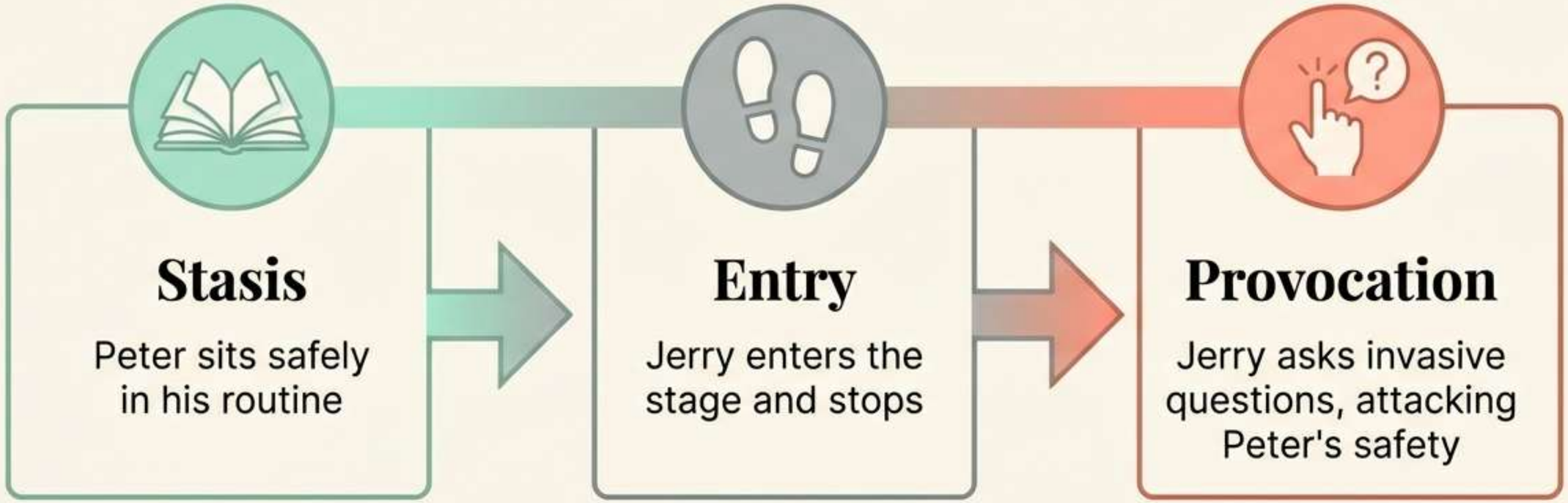
Phase I: The Intrusion



“MISTER, I’VE BEEN TO THE ZOO!”

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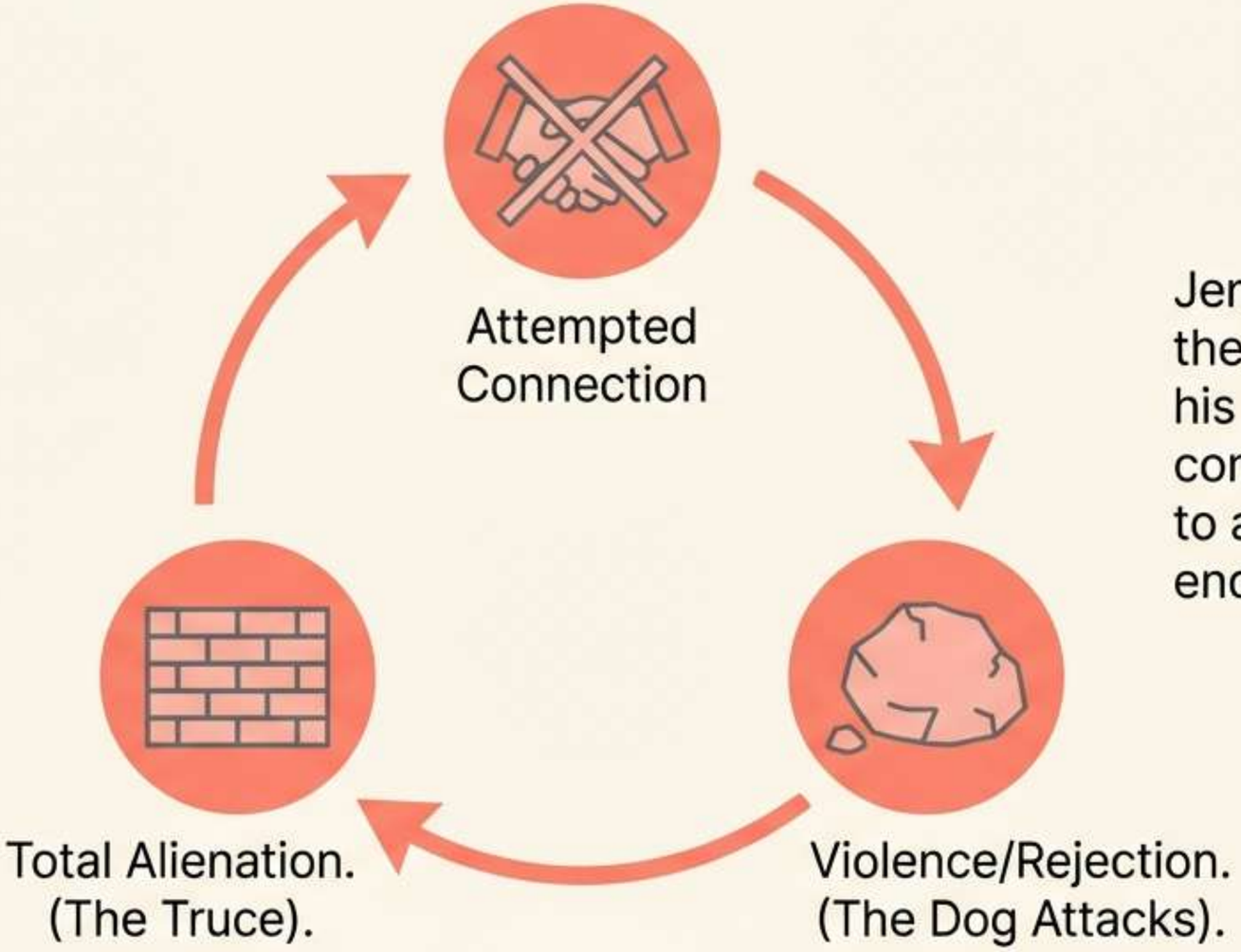
Phase II: The ‘Zoo’ Story



Jerry’s anecdote about the dog is a parable for his life: He tries to connect, fails, resorts to aggression, and ends up more isolated.

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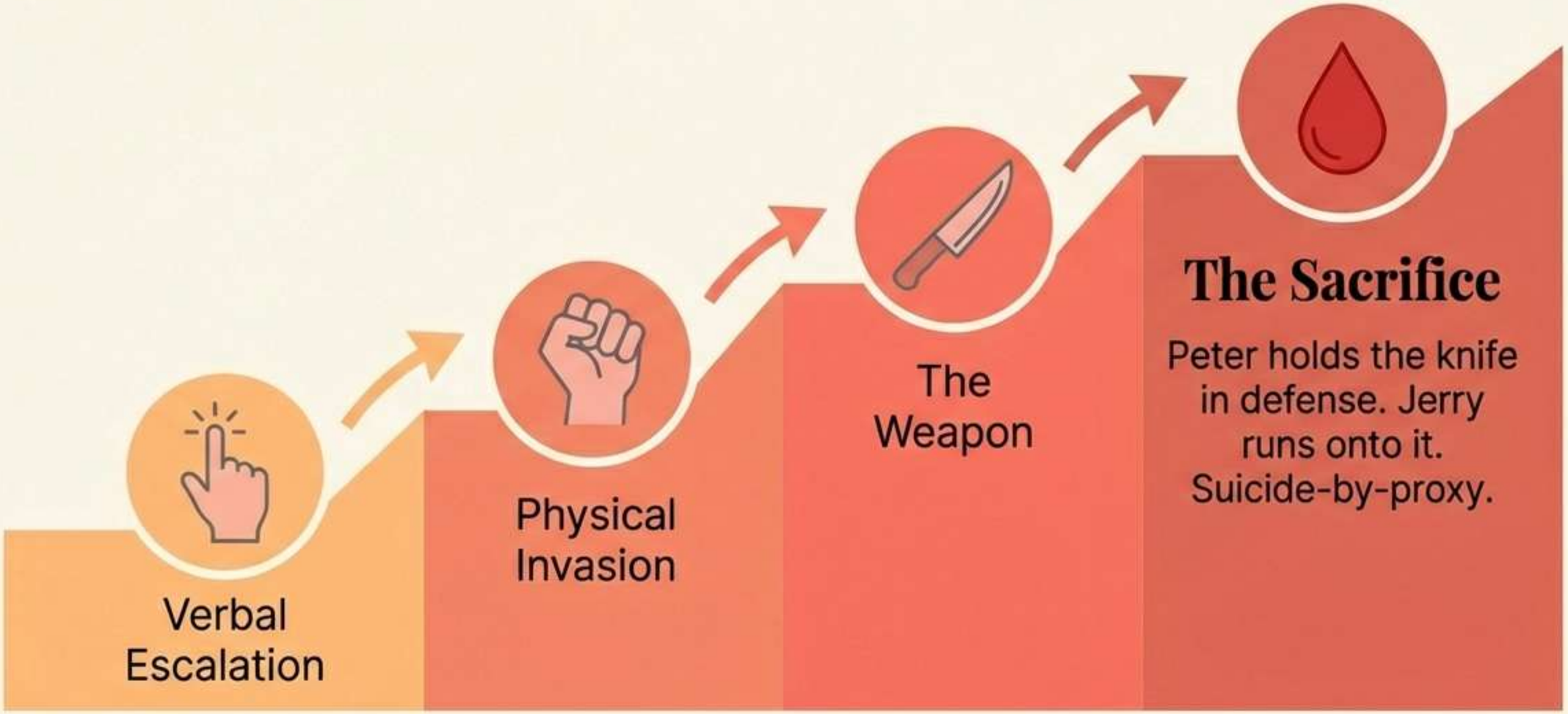
Phase III: The Catastrophe



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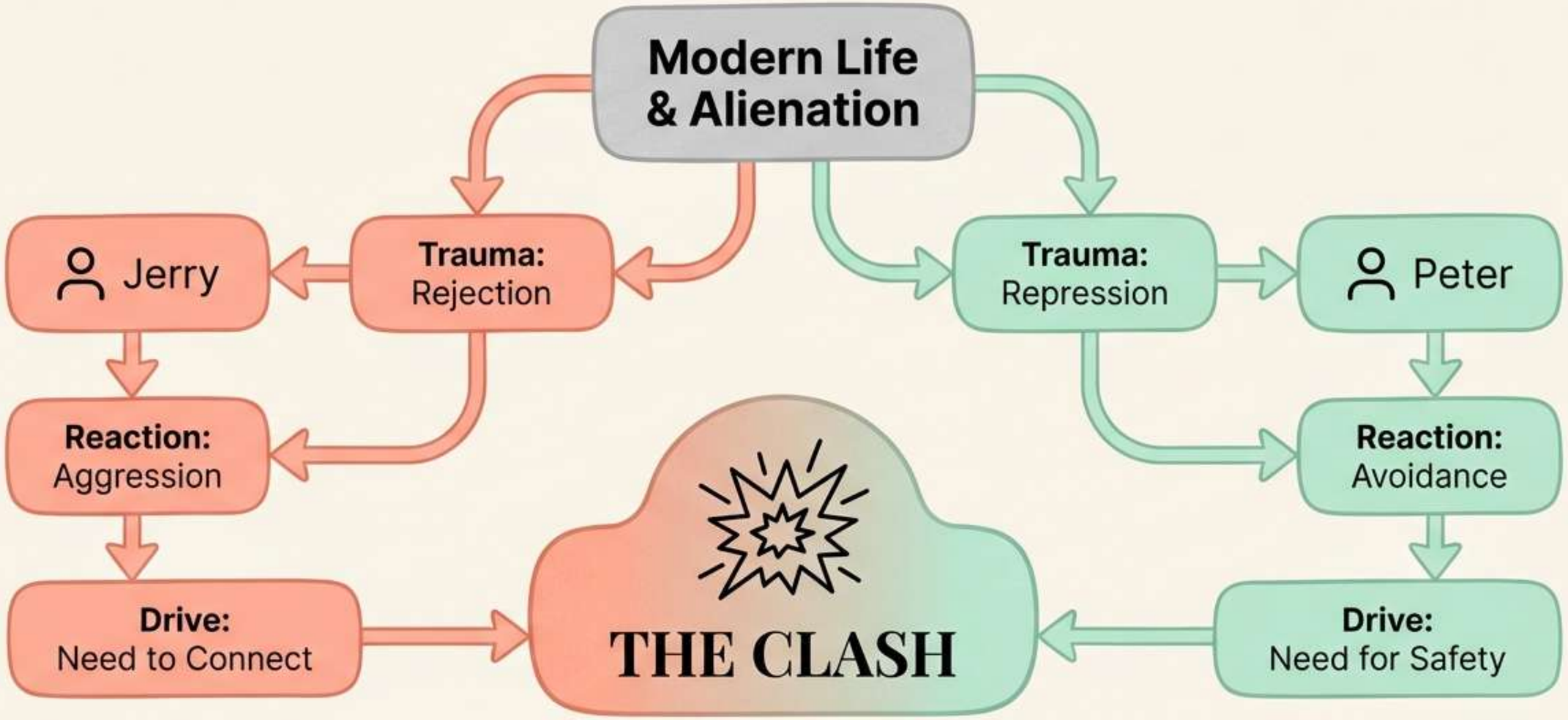
The Psychology Map



Communication fails verbally,
so it must happen violently.

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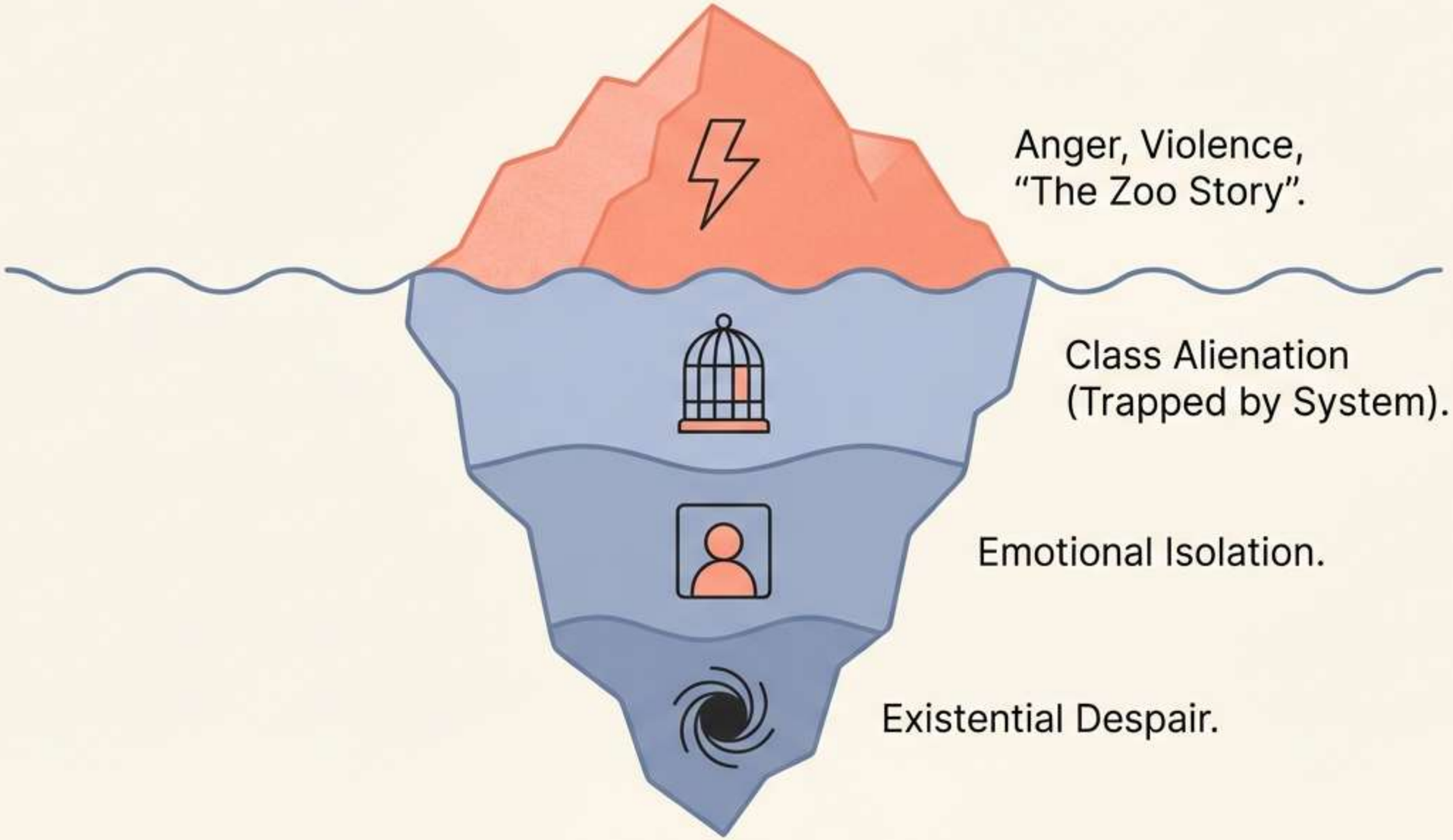
Jerry's Trauma: The Scream



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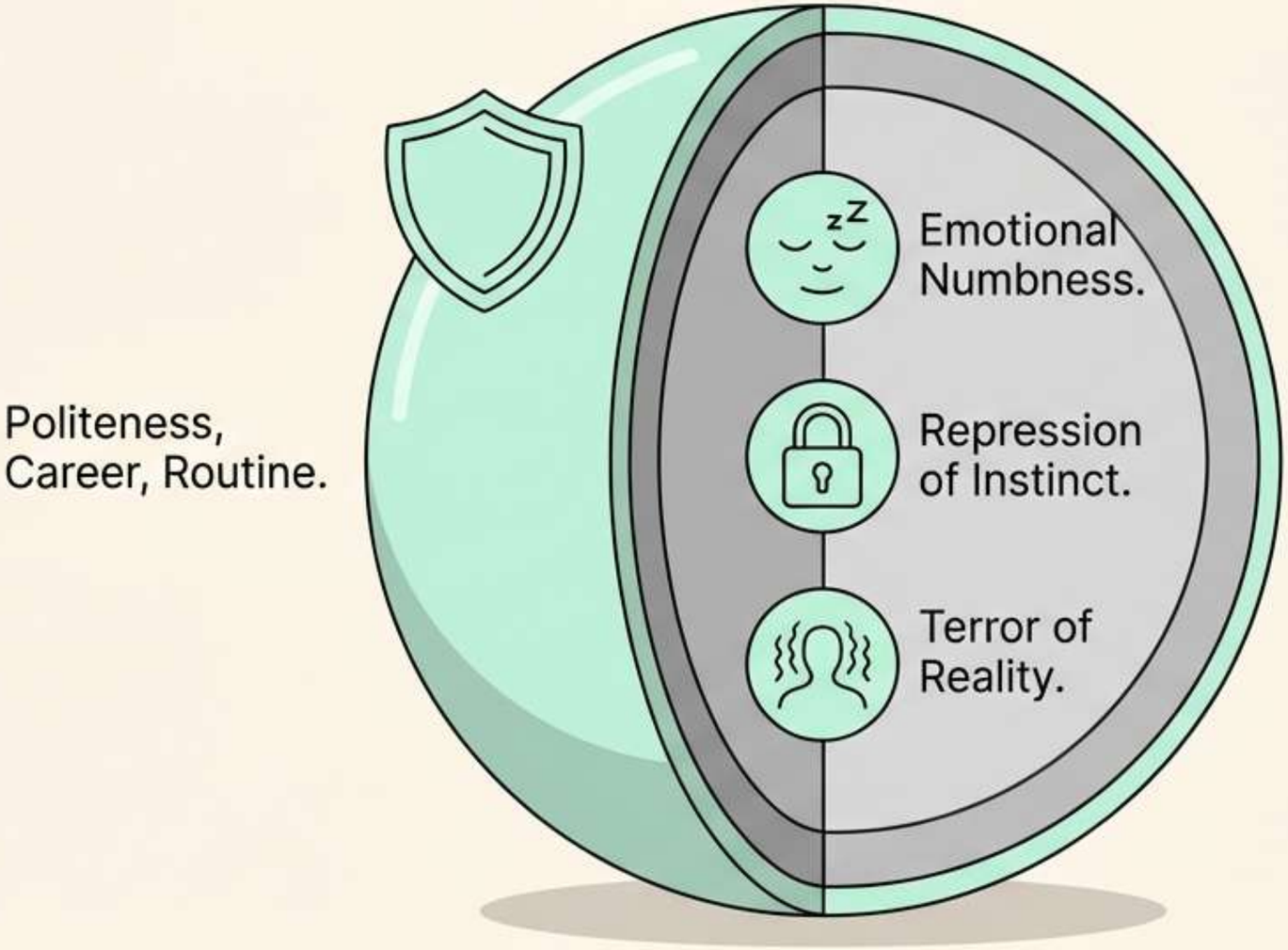
Peter’s Trauma: The Silence



Peter’s sadness is a shallow comfort that masks internal emptiness.

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Thematic Matrix

Alienation

Both characters serve time in their own cages.

Communication Failure

Desire to connect vs. inability. Words fail.

Absurdity

Routine vs. Raw Impulse.

Identity

Forced self-awareness. "You're not a nice person."

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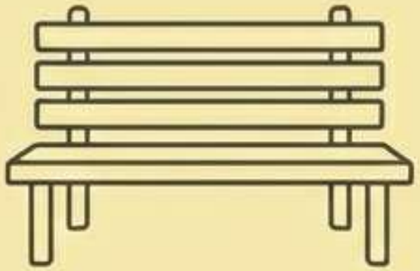
Decoding the Symbols

The Zoo

Society as a cage. We are separated by bars.



The Bench

Status & Possession. The stage for the fight.

The Rocks

Rebellion. A violent attempt to be seen.

The Knife

The Key. The tool for awakening and connection.

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Echoes from the Park

"Sometimes it's necessary to go a long distance out of the way in order to come back a short distance correctly."

DISRUPTION

"You're not really a nice person."

THE MIRROR

"I came unto you at the zoo."

ORIGINS

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The Aftermath

The play ends with a death, but the tragedy belongs to the survivor.

1. Jerry is free (dead).
2. Peter is awake, burdened with the knowledge of the “zoo”.
3. The collision forces us to look in the mirror.

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